

counterpoint

The simultaneous playing or singing of two or more equally important melodic lines.

damper

A device that deadens the vibrations of strings to reduce the volume of a note. In a piano it is a pad that deadens each note as the corresponding key is released.

descant

A melody or counterpoint that accompanies a melody and is higher in pitch. An instrument of higher than normal pitch.

diatonic

Based on a scale of seven natural degrees—five whole steps and two half steps.

dissonance

A combination of notes that clash with one another.

distortion (clipping)

The effect produced by overloading an amplifier so that the sound is distorted. Most commonly associated with the electric guitar.

duet

A composition written for two instruments or voices.

duple meter

A meter with two, or a multiple of two, beats in a measure.

dynamics

Differences in volume of a piece or section of music. Also the notation system used to indicate these differences.

enharmonic note

These are notes that have the same pitch as each other but different names; for example, C $\sharp$ and D $\flat$ are enharmonic notes.

ensemble

A group of musicians.

exposition

The part of a composition where the principal musical themes are first introduced.

faissetto

A technique used by male singers to extend the top of their range.

fantasia

A loosely structured, usually instrumental, composition.

fermata

A symbol used in musical notation over a note, chord, or rest to indicate that it should be sustained for longer than its value indicates. Also called a pause.

figure

A recurring sequence of notes that acts as a musical motif.

figured bass

A bass part with numbers specifying the harmonies to be played above it.

fill

A short passage that runs between the main sections of a melody. Common in pop music.

finale

The last movement of a Classical composition.

finger-picking

A style of guitar-playing in which the right thumb plays the bass strings and the index and middle fingers pick out a melody on the treble strings.

flat

A note that has been lowered by a half step. Also describes an instrument or voice that is out of tune by being lower than the intended pitch.

fugato

A passage written in the manner of a fugue.

fugue

A complex contrapuntal piece in two or more parts.

galant

An elegant musical style of the 18th century.

ground bass

A repeated pattern in the bass part of a musical composition.

half step

Also known as a semitone, this is the smallest musical interval in diatonic harmony

harmonic

A harmonic series consists of the note played and an ascending progression of overtones, which determine the individual timbre of an instrument.

harmony

The grouping of notes to form chords.

homophonic

A style in which a melody line is supported by chordal harmony and a solid bass.

hornpipe

A fast dance tune, often instrumental, originating from 16th-century sailors' dances.

hymn

A religious song that uses the same melody for successive verses and choruses, designed to be sung by a congregation during Christian worship.

improvisation

The art of composing while performing, without the use of written music.

instrumentation

The scoring of music for particular instruments.

interlude

A short piece of music to be played between main sections of a composition.

interval

The difference in pitch between two notes.

intonation

The pitching of a voice or instrument, or the musician's skill at sounding notes in tune.

inversion

Changing the order of the notes in an interval or chord.

jig

A lively dance associated with Celtic music, which is the origin of the jig that often closes Baroque dance suites.

key

The tonal center of a piece of music, based on the first note (tonic) of the scale.

key signature

A group of sharps or flats at the beginning of a staff that indicates which key a piece of music is played in.

keynote

The first note of a scale, also called the tonic.

leading note

The seventh note of a scale, a half step below the tonic.

leitmotif

A recurring musical phrase that relates to a character, emotion, or object.

libretto

The text of an opera.

lick

In jazz and popular music, a short pattern or phrase that is usually a single melodic line.

lyrics

The words to a song.

major

This term can be applied to a key signature or any chord, triad, or scale in a major key. Music in a major key is often described as sounding happy or bright. Major intervals are a half step larger than minor intervals.